THREE MUSKETEERS AND A BLOODY WAR IN FIJI

Narayan Datt Tiwari, an old Congress party loyalist and India's external affairs minister, was sweating when he walked into Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi's inner chamber on the sweltering evening of 14 May 1987. Not because of the summer heat, but because of the bundle of cables and intelligence analysis reports he was carrying that spoke of imminent Chinese aggression on the border.

Rajiv Gandhi carefully went through each page of the files, discussing various factors with Tiwari that might influence dealings on this external risk. When Tiwari left, the tension in the room left no space for an affable goodbye.

Rajiv Gandhi had settled well into the pace of his new life since the assassination of his charismatic mother, Indira Gandhi, in 1984. But since 1986, events in Bangladesh, Sri Lanka and Pakistan, which carried shadows of long term consequences in the neighbourhood, had threatened the relative peace of his days at the South Block. Before he could pack up for the day, the secure red phone on the right corner of his table crackled to life. The island nation of Fiji, seven thousand and two hundred miles from New Delhi, with 49 per cent of its population consisting of ethnic Indians, had had a bloodless coup just a few hours earlier, toppling the Indian-dominated Fijian government.

Gandhi was stunned. India was not only facing increasing threats from Pakistan and Sri Lanka, but the administration in 1987 was also dealing with both a terrible drought in some states and terrible floods in other states, threatening the